



of women's monthly cycles) dictate special times of worship. Followers of Wicca identify with the natural world in the belief that we are all a divine aspect of it. Divinity, as defined by the wonders of nature, is as much in all our beings as it is in every river, mountain, tree, and animal. Magic in the sense that the world, and the universe, is inherently magical remains a basic Wiccan belief. The original Gardnerian Wicca, as it became known, had rules for ritual initiations, but later

versions were more fluid in their understanding of magic. As a 21st-century Wiccan put it: "The fact that the sun rises every morning and we are here to see it is magic." Apart from the creed of "harm none" and magical celebration of the natural world, sub-group after sub-group has broken off from Gardner's original vision. The first to challenge him, in the 1950s, was one of his disciples, Doreen Valiente. Her purpose was not to dispute Gardner's vision but to purify it. Other rival cults followed.

▲ The mystical pentacle

The five points of the pentacle, also called a pentagram, represent earth, water, air, fire, and spirit. Its circle suggests wholeness and unity with the natural world.